

Fact Sheet Notes and Template

NOTES:

Use the A—>B | B—>C strategy between bullet points to keep them brief. E.g. below:

The world's gasoline and natural gas reserves will be expended by 2060 at their current rate of use (Stanford, 2019).

When those reserves dry up, having suitable renewable energy infrastructure in place will be critical.

Without that infrastructure, we will have no way to replace the ~83% of US energy supplied by fossil fuels (US Energy Information Administration, 2024).

When such an energy gap exists, economists predict an unprecedented economic shock contributing to major job losses, recession, brownouts, and failure to provide public services.

The format follows a problem, cause, solution, effect model. This examines the problem's pertinence, the problem's cause, how the solution addresses that underlying cause, and the solution's outcomes.

Use reliable sources, and nonpartisan ones if possible. If you do want to use something from Heritage, Cato, CAP, or IPS, balance it out with sources from the other side or trusted nonpartisan sources corroborating that link.

NIH, economics journals, and university policy reviews are often the best places to search for reliable quantitative evidence.

Avoid trope-y policies when conducting research to determine what the best solution is. The common-sense or hot-button policies often aren't the most effective solutions.

E.g. When Andrew Mellon and the Coolidge administration cut the tax rate, federal revenue increased because the wealthy stopped hiding money with tax shelters and fraud.

Keep the final fact sheet to two Google Docs pages. Staffers like to be able to hold onto your information, and a double sided 'one-pager' works best with most filing systems.

TEMPLATE:

One sentence summary of the policy + bill number/name

What is the problem in the status quo?

This is where you're going to break down what specific social harms a policy should try to correct.

Who specifically is being harmed?

In what ways do the harms vary across racial, geographic, age, economic lines?

What is the quantifiable loss/decrease in quality of life?

How can we expect this to worsen over time if this issue is ignored?

Why should we make this a priority right now?

What externalities arise due to this social issue?

There are usually multiple bad things that result from a single social issue, the more you can identify, the better you can make solving it a priority for legislators across the spectrum of ideologies and priorities.

How did this problem arise?

This is where you will identify why this problem is here. You can't fix something if you don't know why it's broken, so this is a sort of diagnostic stage.

Dig into the history of social and political debates over this issue. Who won? What norms, precedents, funding, or regulation went into effect that shouldn't have?

What political or social stakeholders have a particular hand in causing or solving this problem? What has held up its correction in the past?

Is there a specific place in legislation that creates a loophole, inequality, lack of clarity, or poor implementation?

What is the specific mechanism by which social institutions contribute to or allow this issue?

What are some worries about dealing with this problem? Are there negative externalities we can expect if we try to fix this problem?

What are some potential confounding variables underlying this issue? How do you know you've found the right variable?

How does the proposed policy correct that problem?

This is where you will prove efficacy; now that you know how a flaw contributes to this issue, you have to prove that your proposed solution will actually address that flaw and has a better-than-not chance of working as intended.

What specifically does your policy proposal do to address the flaw identified above?

Is there any accepted knowledge around this type of policy's effects?

E.g. Excise taxes decrease demand for a product.

What do the economic/social scientific predictions say about the effects of such a policy?

Are there any pilot programs for this? Oftentimes localities or specific states will have already tried something, and you can pull data and findings from those case studies to show that your policy is likely to work the same.

Are there any variables at play that could reduce your policy's chances of working as intended? Check nationwide economic conditions; racial, rural, and economic disparities; recent policy and funding changes; existing regulations, definitions, and programs that may interfere with your policy.

What impacts can we expect by passing this policy?

This is where you bring it all home by quantifying just how much America will benefit from your solution. Tie everything back to the first section to show how those harms will be prevented.

Who stands to benefit from this policy?

How many lives will be saved, how much money will go back into people's pockets, how effectively will certain behaviors be prevented, and how widespread will the benefits be?

What other impacts happen when that money goes back into people's pockets, when lives are saved?

Will the result be more or less equality?

This is a good place to build impacts out as much as possible. Even a couple more grand per year per household has quantitative linkages to educational outcomes, social mobility. Improving workforce equity has direct impacts on GDP growth, federal spending, and mortality rate. Draw out these links and positive externalities.

Weigh the impacts. This is where you address both negative and positive outcomes of your solution and look to see in what categories your policy wins and loses in. After reading this, you should be able to confidently say every single thing that happens if you pass this policy and can quantify and explain how the problem is addressed.